Digital Humanities and Environmental Sustainability at the British Library

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The British Library's approach to digital humanities and environmental sustainability reflects its broader commitment to sustainability within the Library and its role in national and international networks. This topic intersects with various operational areas such as technology architecture, data management, and web design, extending beyond the remit of the Library's Digital Research Team, the natural 'home' for digital humanities in the organisation. Key considerations include topics such as data management, the carbon footprint of software, hardware reusability, energy efficiency, and the use of AI—all central to how we leverage technology responsibly across diverse purposes and align with broader environmental goals.

In this presentation, I will focus on the British Library as a case study, discussing initiatives aimed at increasing literacy and capacity building, both within the Library but also externally, fostering personal agency, and encouraging action using both bottom-up and top-down approaches. These efforts not only reflect the Library's internal sustainability goals but also support wider efforts in the cultural heritage sector to address environmental challenges collaboratively, promoting shared learning and innovation.

A significant example is the staff-led Sustainability Group, a network designed to empower staff to take personal action on sustainability. This group also serves as a valuable communication channel, with initiatives like a quarterly newsletter and a Teams space for sharing ideas and promoting best practices. One notable output was a "green poster" that provided practical tips for sustainable workplace practices, including a "Smarter Digital" section advocating for reduced file sharing and retention. A survey revealed that many staff were unaware of technology's environmental impact but were eager to learn more, highlighting the importance of ongoing education and practical guidance.

A couple of years after forming the Sustainability Group, the Library appointed a Sustainability Manager to coordinate efforts to minimise the environmental impact of its operations—such as heating, lighting, travel, and waste—and to explore how its collections and partnerships could support climate action. The publication of the Library's first *Sustainability and Climate Change Strategy* (British Library 2024) marked a significant milestone. This strategy underscores a commitment to decarbonising operations, improving environmental performance, and embedding sustainability into the Library's culture, processes, and governance. Two key elements relevant to this discussion are the focus on technology infrastructure and the pivotal role of staff in driving positive environmental change through informed decision-making and everyday practices.

To empower staff, we have been developing tailored learning initiatives and integrating sustainability training into existing induction and development programmes. These provide staff with the tools to incorporate sustainable practices into their daily work. From a digital humanities perspective, I will highlight a webinar and workshop hosted in collaboration with the Digital Humanities Climate Coalition (DHCC) in late 2023 and early 2024. This collaboration emphasised minimising the environmental impact of digital humanities research, using the DHCC's toolkit to guide staff in making more sustainable digital choices and fostering climate-responsible practices (Digital Humanities Climate Coalition 2025). A follow-up staff survey captured the impact of this initiative and revealed that some participants have embedded toolkit recommendations, made specific changes in their work, shared knowledge and influenced their wider networks. The survey also highlighted perceived challenges or barriers to change making, such as organisational culture (Keinan-Schoonbaert 2024).

The DHCC training was followed by a multimodal training series entitled *Discovering Digital Sustainability* , which took place during March 2025. This month-long series of events explored the intersection of environmental sustainability and technology, featuring a blend of talks, hands-on workshops, and a dedicated reading group session. Staff learned from leading voices in heritage and academic institutions, technology providers, and colleagues who are actively working to reduce their carbon footprint by adopting greener technologies, rethinking workflows, and making sustainable decisions. These events were hosted as part of the Library's Digital Scholarship Training Programme (DSTP), a professional development initiative that has been running since 2012. I will share the results of a feedback survey, which aimed to assess the impact of this series. Survey

results reflect that many topics were new to participants, and that there are intentions to further share knowledge and implement learning in ones' personal life and professional practices.

Finally, I will touch on the *LIBER Digital Scholarship & Data Science Essentials for Library Professionals* , an open, collaboratively curated training resource designed to support research library professionals (LIBER 2025). Unlike the internal initiatives mentioned earlier, this resource is outward facing, providing overviews of key technologies in digital scholarship and data science, alongside trusted training material recommendations. With contributions and suggestions from members of staff, I'm in the process of developing a topic guide on Digital Humanities and Environmental Sustainability. This guide will introduce the topic, recommend hands-on tutorials, highlight use cases, and provide links to articles, videos, networks, and communities of practice. While these resources will play an essential role in fostering environmental awareness and sustainable practices across the global library community in particular, they will also be useful more widely, in the heritage sector as well as beyond.

Bibliography

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